

Cacao Beverage Opportunity

China Market & TCM Product Strategy + Operating P&L

Initial Go-to-Market Network Expansion Channels:

Dr. Ye (TCM) · Liz's Cousin (Market Insider) · Chaoshan Group

Compiled by: Sophia Truesight — TrueSight DAO

July 13, 2026

Executive Summary

"Nobody in China is making cacao drinks yet." — Confirmed independently by Dr. Ye (TCM) and Liz's cousin (market insider).

Three initial network expansion channels drive the go-to-market strategy: **Dr. Ye** (TCM content + Douyin weight-loss account), **Liz's Cousin** (market insider), and **Chaoshan Group** (regional distribution). Sales, marketing, and events budgets are allocated to expand these networks.

China health tea market: **¥642.7 billion** (2025), growing 25.3% YoY, projected >¥100 billion by 2028. Cacao husk tea as a category is completely empty in mainland China.

Operating model: **Min Viable Scale = 219 boxes/month** (~8.8 kg cacao tea) to cover \$9,833 monthly OpEx. At conservative scale (500 boxes/mo): **\$13,040/mo net profit**.

Every SKU sold reserves **\$5 → 1 cacao tree → 4 tons carbon credit**.

Part 1: Market Opportunity

"中国可卡的饮料还没有人做" — Cacao drinks in China have no domestic player yet.

- China health tea market: ¥642.7B (2025, +25.3% YoY), projected >¥1T by 2028

- Cacao husk tea category: **completely empty** in mainland China
- Existing cacao tea brands (Dedicated Chocolate HK, Rayca's HK, Hara Teas, Cacao Tea Co.) — all overseas, none on Taobao/Tmall/JD
- Weight-loss/slimming demand: high traffic conversion rates (confirmed by Dr. Ye's market observation)
- Convenience product direction: cacao shell tea bags (泡/煮茶) — multi-functional, regional-limited editions

Target Segments

Segment	Size Indicator	Channel Access
Health-conscious women (25-45)	Core health tea consumers	Dr. Ye's Douyin accounts
TCM / wellness seekers	¥642B health tea market	Dr. Ye's TCM audience
Coffee alternative drinkers	Growing specialty tea market	Chaoshan network
Gift / premium market	小罐茶 brand perception	Liz's cousin + events

Part 2: Competitive Landscape

Direct Competitors (Cacao Husk Tea)

Brand	Price	Channel	China Mainland?
Dedicated Chocolate (HK)	~HKD 68	Website, HK only	☐
Rayca's Dancing Tea (HK)	HKD 12-168	Website, HK only	☐
Hara Teas (Overseas)	~USD 10-15	Website only	☐
Cacao Tea Co. (USA)	~USD 12-18	Website, cross-border	☐
Conspiracy Chocolate	~USD 10	Website only	☐

Key finding: None available on Taobao/Tmall/JD. All overseas/HK. **Blue ocean.**

Indirect Competitors (Health Tea Bags)

Brand	Price	Positioning
同仁堂 (Tongrentang)	¥30-80	Heritage TCM leader
忆江南 (Yijiangnan)	¥20-50	Mass-market health tea
草木方 (Caomufang)	¥25-60	New-style health tea
茶里 (CHALI)	¥30-80	New-style bagged tea

立顿 (Lipton)	¥20-40	International brand
-------------	--------	---------------------

Differentiation Matrix

Dimension	Existing Health Teas	Cacao Husk Tea (Us)
Market	Red ocean (established brands)	Blue ocean — no domestic player
Raw material	Herbs / flowers	Cacao shell (circular economy)
Flavor	Herbal taste	Natural chocolate aroma
Caffeine	Varies	Very low (theobromine only)
Antioxidants	Moderate	Higher than green tea
TCM integration	Mature system	Blank — can define new "warming, heart-nourishing" category
Sustainability	Standard	\$5/SKU → 1 tree → 4 tons carbon credit

Part 3: Science & TCM Integration

Cacao Health Benefits (Peer-Reviewed)

- **Cardiovascular:** Nitric oxide production, lowers blood pressure, reduces LDL, improves endothelial function
- **Cognitive:** Increases cerebral blood flow, improves memory, may reduce dementia risk
- **Mood:** 70% lower depression risk in high-cacao consumers; theobromine provides温和提神
- **Anti-inflammatory & Antioxidant:** ORAC score ~97,000 — 4× superfoods like acai/goji
- **Metabolic:** Anti-diabetic, anti-obesity, anti-carcinogenic properties

Cacao Shell Tea vs Green Tea

Metric	Cacao Tea	Green Tea
Antioxidants	Higher (flavonoids)	Lower
Theobromine	High (温和提神)	Negligible
Caffeine	Low	Medium
Heart health	Stronger	Protective
Sugar/Fat	Zero	Zero

TCM Classification

Property	Value
Nature (性)	Warming (温)
Taste (味)	Bitter, Slightly Pungent (苦、微辛)
Meridians (归经)	Heart, Liver, Kidney (心、肝、肾)
Therapeutic Actions	Tonify Heart Qi · Warm Kidney Yang · Invigorate Blood · Calm Shen (补心、温肾阳、活血、安神、祛寒)

TCM Tea Blend Formulas

Formula	TCM Focus	Key Herbs
Heart-Nourishing (养心安神)	Fatigue, cold hands, mild depression	Cacao shell + goji + red dates + licorice
Digestive-Warming (温中健脾)	Cold digestion, bloating	Cacao shell + ginger + chen pi + cinnamon
Liver-Soothing (疏肝解郁)	Stress, PMS, irritability	Cacao shell + chrysanthemum + mint + rose
Kidney-Warming (温肾壮阳)	Low energy, low libido	Cacao shell + goji + cinnamon + schisandra

Part 4: Operating P&L Model

4.1 Product Specification — 小罐茶 Style

Item	Spec
Serving size	4g per can
Box size	10 cans = 40g per box
Units per kg	250 boxes
Retail price	\$50/box (Liz's suggestion)

4.2 Cost of Goods Sold (Per Box — 40g)

Raw Material: AGL8 — La Dio Sitio Farm (Paulo, Pará)

Component	Per kg	Per Box
Cacao husk (byproduct from nib/choc production)	\$4.50	\$0.18

Processing (clean, roast, grind for tea)	\$3.00	\$0.12
Ex-factory Brazil	\$7.50	\$0.30

Packaging (Shenzhen — Source Pack Co)

Item	Per Box
Aluminum can ×10 (小罐茶 style)	\$1.50
Outer box	\$0.30
Tea filter bag ×10	\$0.50
Packaging subtotal	\$2.30

⚠ **NEED: Packaging pricing from Ling**

Freight (Brazil Ilhéus → Shenzhen, China)

Method	Rate/kg	Per Box
Air freight (consolidated, 100+ kg)	\$4-5/kg	\$0.18
DHL Express (samples only)	\$15-20/kg	\$0.70
Sea freight (container, 1000+ kg)	\$1-2/kg	\$0.06

Use Seacos/Omega forwarders (existing partners). DHL is 3-4x — samples only.

Total COGS per Box

Component	Cost	% of \$50
Cacao tea + processing	\$0.30	0.6%
Packaging	\$2.30	4.6%
Freight (air consolidated)	\$0.18	0.4%
Customs/duties (~5-15%)	\$0.14	0.3%
Total COGS	\$2.92	5.8%
Gross Profit	\$47.08	94.2%

4.3 Carbon Credit Reserve

Metric	Per Box
Carbon reserve (per SKU sold)	\$5.00
Cacao trees planted	1 tree

Carbon credits generated	4 tons CO ₂
--------------------------	------------------------

Net revenue after carbon reserve: **\$45.00/box**. Profit adjusted accordingly.

4.4 Revised P&L — Net After Carbon Reserve

Component	Per Box
Retail price	\$50.00
– Carbon reserve (→ reforestation)	–\$5.00
Net revenue	\$45.00
– COGS	–\$2.92
Gross profit (after carbon)	\$42.08

4.5 Operating Expenses (Monthly)

Category	Monthly	Annual	Channel Served
Team — Jerrie (operations)	\$1,000	\$12,000	All channels
Team — Ling (packaging/logistics)	\$1,000	\$12,000	All channels
Liz — Sales & marketing (KOL wining/ dining)	\$2,000	\$24,000	Dr. Ye / Cousin / Chaoshan expansion
Marketing content production	\$1,000	\$12,000	Dr. Ye's Douyin content
Events & KOL activations	\$3,333	\$40,000	2 events/yr × \$20K — drives all 3 channels
Warehousing (Shenzhen)	\$500	\$6,000	All channels
Legal & compliance (China)	\$500	\$6,000	All channels
Miscellaneous	\$500	\$6,000	All channels
Total Monthly OPEX	\$9,833	\$118,000	
+ One-time setup		\$10,000	Branding, packaging design, regulatory
Total Year 1 OpEx		\$128,000	

Network Expansion Budget: Liz's \$2,000/mo sales & marketing + \$40,000/yr events = **\$64,000/yr dedicated to expanding Dr. Ye, Cousin, and Chaoshan channels**. This is the core GTM investment.

4.6 Minimum Viable Scale — Units Required

To cover monthly operating expenses of **\$9,833**, you need to sell **219 boxes per month** at \$45 net revenue per box. That's just **~8.8 kg of cacao tea** per month.

Timeframe	Boxes Needed	Net Revenue	COGS	Net Profit	Cacao Tea
Per month (min viable)	219 boxes	\$9,855	\$639	\$16	~8.8 kg
Per quarter	657 boxes	\$29,565	\$1,918	\$47	~26 kg
Per year (break-even)	2,844 boxes	\$127,980	\$8,304	\$0 (B/E)	~114 kg

At **219 boxes/month** you sustain operations with near-zero loss. This is the floor — every box beyond that is pure profit.

4.7 Monthly Revenue Scenarios

Scenario	Boxes	Net Revenue	COGS	OpEx	Net Profit	Trees	Carbon (t)
Min Viable Scale	219	\$9,855	\$639	\$9,833	\$16	219	876
Conservative	500	\$22,500	\$1,460	\$9,833	\$11,207	500	2,000
Moderate	1,000	\$45,000	\$2,920	\$9,833	\$32,247	1,000	4,000
Growth	2,500	\$112,500	\$7,300	\$11,833	\$93,367	2,500	10,000
Scale	5,000	\$225,000	\$14,600	\$16,833	\$193,567	5,000	20,000

Annual Carbon Impact at Scale

Scale	Boxes/Yr	Revenue After Carbon	Trees/Yr	Carbon Credits (tons)	Reforestation Fund
Growth	30,000	\$1,350,000	30,000	120,000	\$150,000
Scale	60,000	\$2,700,000	60,000	240,000	\$300,000

Part 5: Product Line & Pricing

Tier	Product	Price
1	Pure cacao shell tea (小罐茶 style, 40g)	\$50
2	4 TCM functional blends (40g)	\$55-60
3	Seasonal limited editions	\$65-80
4	Regional editions — 因地制宜 (incl. Chaoshan)	\$55-70
5	Chocolate bar + recipe kit	\$15-25

Part 6: Funding Requirements

Use	Amount
Initial inventory (50 kg cacao tea from AGL8)	\$375
Packaging (5,000 units — aluminum cans + boxes)	\$11,500
Freight (50 kg air, Brazil→China)	\$250
Branding & packaging design	\$3,000
China food import compliance	\$3,000
Operating reserve (6 months)	\$59,000
Marketing launch (KOLs, 1 event)	\$25,000
Contingency (15%)	\$15,319
Total	~\$117,444

Part 7: Open Items

Item	Owner	Status
Packaging pricing (aluminum cans, boxes, labels)	Ling	⚠ NEED
Packaging details (materials, dimensions, artwork)	Ling	⚠ NEED
Events budget — confirmed 2 events/yr × \$20K	Liz	✅ DONE
KOL partnership budget and target list	Liz	⚠ NEED
China food import regulations (cacao husk tea)	Legal	⚠ NEED
Dr. Ye's Douyin side account launch timing	Dr. Ye	⚠ PENDING
Chaoshan group introduction and partnership terms	Liz	⚠ PENDING